FULL CARD 21 — Historical Change and Evidence

SOCIAL STUDIES • HISTORY • CAUSATION • SOURCE CRITICISM

BIG IDEA • Change is caused by several connected factors—not one isolated event.

A timeline is a tool for ordering events, but historians also ask what changed, what continued, whose perspective is represented, and what evidence supports a claim.

Cause, event, consequence

Factor	How it can influence change	Evidence to look for
Economic	Taxation, trade, land revenue, access to resources	Revenue records, prices, accounts
Political	Power struggles, laws, alliances, administrative decisions	Orders, official correspondence
Social	Inequality, education, community networks, public opinion	Petitions, newspapers, oral histories
Technology	Transport, communication, weapons, production methods	Objects, technical records, maps
Environment	Drought, flood, disease, changing land use	Climate records, local accounts

Source comparison

Source	Strength	Limitation
Official proclamation	Shows the public position of an authority	May omit dissent or practical effects
Personal diary	Can reveal lived experience and emotion	Represents one person's viewpoint
Newspaper report	Provides contemporary claims and dates	May reflect editorial or political bias
Later history book	Can compare multiple sources	Interpretation depends on evidence selected

Worked reasoning: A tax increase is followed by protest. The sequence alone does not prove the tax was the only cause. Compare timing with petitions, economic conditions, leadership, and other grievances.

Exam structure: Make a claim → use a specific piece of evidence → explain how it supports the claim → add a limitation or alternative explanation.

Practice: Choose one event from the timeline. Give one possible political cause, one economic cause, and one question a historian should ask before deciding which mattered most.